

Against Moral Intuitionism

Question: Philosophy 1—Should we trust our ‘moral intuitions’?

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I. Introduction

In this paper, I contend that we have no reason to trust our moral intuitions: they are epistemically unreliable, subject to persistent disagreement, and rest on a deeply questionable metaphysical foundation.

To limit the scope of our discussion, I will be focusing on a foundationalist interpretation of intuition as a means of knowledge production.¹ As such, an intuition shall thereby be defined as a self-evident “intellectual seeming.”² Moral intuitionism, on this view, is the use of intuition as an epistemic tool regarding moral matters, and it carries a non-naturalist, realist commitment to the objectivity of those matters.³ Since moral intuitionism presupposes moral realism, arguments against the latter are equally arguments against the former.

II. Argument from Unreliability

Unlike perception, intuition is notoriously unreliable. While not infallible, perceptual seemings (the sensory analog of intellectual seemings) are typically considered reliable because they can be checked against contextual cues. In other words, when weather phenomena obscure vision or when we are physically impaired, we are less apt to trust our perceptual seemings.⁴ Intellectual seemings, on the other hand, lack the capacity to receive reliable feedback contextually.⁵

¹ Britannica, “Intuition.”

² Audi, “Self-Evidence”; Bealer, “Intuition and the Autonomy of Philosophy,” 10; Chudnoff, *Intuition*; Huemer, *Ethical Intuitionism*, 102; Ogar et al., “A Critique of Ethical Intuitionism as the Foundation of Knowledge,” 1.

³ Ethics Unwrapped, “Moral Philosophy”; Stratton-Lake, “Intuitionism in Ethics.”

⁴ Cecchini, “The Reliability Challenge to Moral Intuitions,” 8.

⁵ DeStefano, “The Reliability and Nature of Philosophical Intuitions,” 17–18.

Additionally, the non-naturalness of moral intuitions implies that they are causally inert, i.e., they can neither affect nor be affected by other causal processes. Therefore, moral intuitions cannot be caused by their corresponding moral truths.⁶

Moral intuitions are also subject to various distorting factors.

First, phraseology. Studies have concluded that when the trolley problem was presented with “saving language,” people overwhelmingly chose to flip the switch; the opposite occurred when “killing language” was employed.⁷

Second, partiality. One might have ulterior motives for experiencing certain intuitions.⁸ For example, judging two piano performances, the father of one of the contestants would, intuitively, think that his daughter played better, though this might not be justified without familial association.⁹

Third, disgust. Disgust elicited by physical or chemical stimuli and disgust regarding some moral prospects, respectively, have been shown to influence the moral intuitive process.¹⁰

Moreover, other factors also influence intuition. These include the ordering of cases involving intuition, the hunger level of intuitive moral agents, and the “Knobe effect,” i.e., the tendency to attribute intentionality to negative side effects more readily than to positive ones.¹¹

Jonathan Smith argues that the partiality objection is imprecise. Concerning the example mentioned previously, Smith argues that a piano performance is incomparable with moral intuition. There are nuances and particularities present in musical performances that are not present in the fundamental claims of basic moral intuition (e.g., murder is bad). He presents a counterexample: two contestants play a single note and are judged based on proximity with a third note. Thereby, if the father judges that the note his daughters played was closer, then he

⁶ Hayward, “Immoral Realism,” 1; Stratton-Lake, “Intuitionism in Ethics.”

⁷ Bengson, “Experimental Attacks on Intuitions and Answers,” 6.

⁸ Sinnott-Armstrong, “Moral Intuitionism Meets Empirical Psychology,” 343–46.

⁹ Sinnott-Armstrong, “Moral Intuitionism Meets Empirical Psychology,” 343.

¹⁰ Tao et al., “Effects of Core Disgust and Moral Disgust on Moral Judgment,” 8.

¹¹ Swain et al., “The Instability of Philosophical Intuitions”; Danziger et al., “Extraneous Factors in Judicial Decisions,” 6890; Zucchelli et al., “Intentionality Attribution and Emotion,” 1.

would be justified in believing that his daughter won, regardless of his familial predisposition towards her.¹²

Though I agree that the father would be justified in the second instance, this argument assumes a moral realist conclusion. A better reformulation of the piano competition would be one in which the two contestants are simply told to play one note. The father is then asked, “Who played better?” By eliminating the intended note (or, when applied to the topic of moral intuitionism, some accepted moral principles), partiality comes back into play.

Considering another possibility, Dario Cecchini suggests that the strength of intuition may be a method of tracking the potential reliability of intuition in a context-sensitive way. This would only be the case if one truly accepts moral intuitions proportional to confidence in said intuitions and that such confidence is epistemically reliable.¹³

Nonetheless, there are inconsistencies in this argument. The idea that intuitive strength is epistemically reliable remains hotly contested, as it currently lacks sufficient empirical study.¹⁴ Furthermore, it seems unlikely that one would be able to prove the epistemic reliability of moral intuitions, given that intuitive strength itself is subject to distorting factors such as the Dunning-Kruger effect or the “consensuality principle.”¹⁵ Furthermore, Cecchini's argument implies that self-evidence is strength-dependent, which directly contradicts the standard definition of self-evidence as independent of degree.

III. Argument from Disagreement

One might assume that since moral intuition is “self-evident” and “non-inferential,” there would be harmony among moral agents. Yet, this is not the case. When ten diverse societies were examined for their views regarding moral principles, each “exhibited substantial variation not only in the degree to which such [moral] factors were viewed as excusing, but also in the kinds of [moral] factors taken to provide exculpatory excuses, and in the types of norm violations for

¹² Smith, “On Sinnott-Armstrong’s Case Against Moral Intuitionism,” 77.

¹³ Cecchini, “The Reliability Challenge to Moral Intuitions,” 11.

¹⁴ Cecchini, “The Reliability Challenge to Moral Intuitions,” 22.

¹⁵ Cecchini, “The Reliability Challenge to Moral Intuitions,” 23–24; Dunning, “The Dunning-Kruger Effect,” 259–62; Koriat, “The Self-Consistency Model of Subjective Confidence.”

which such [moral] factors were seen as relevant.”¹⁶ If the moral intuitions of two unprejudiced individuals persistently disagree on some moral issue, then the realist basis for intuitionism would be compromised.¹⁷

In addition, what seems “moral” to us may be evolutionarily favored biological responses. We have evolved to react to different moral acts with either approval or disapproval based on biological necessity, preventing us from attaining genuine knowledge of objective moral facts.¹⁸ Differences in moral beliefs have also been observed across developmental stages and between modern and traditional societies.¹⁹ The disagreement between moral collectivists and individualists is especially notable: moral realists typically argue that such disagreements are not genuinely persistent, but Goldman demonstrates that this claim is unfounded.²⁰

Some proponents of moral intuitionism argue that moral disagreements are, in fact, caused by morally irrelevant factors such as disagreement over related empirical facts or the strength of certain moral reasoning. Let us consider whether it is morally acceptable to boil a lobster alive. While it is *prima facie* a moral problem, it can be reformulated into an empirical question regarding whether the lobster experiences pain. That is, if the lobster did not experience pain, then we would have less objection to boiling the lobster.²¹

Nevertheless, this is a shallow argument, as non-moral disagreements are not the true point of contention in a moral issue. In comparison with the previous example, we would certainly object if a living person were to be boiled, even without experiencing pain. The question again returns to a moral one: Are the lives of a lobster and a person worth the same? If one continues to argue that “worth” could be determined via some empirical measure, e.g., brain capacity, then a new moral issue emerges: is it morally acceptable to boil some organism simply based on the metric of brain capacity? This line of argument generates an infinite regress.

¹⁶ “Small-Scale Societies Exhibit Fundamental Variation in the Role of Intentions in Moral Judgment,” 4692.

¹⁷ Sidgwick, *The Methods of Ethics*, 208–10; Shafer-Landau, *Whatever Happened to Good and Evil?*, 44.

¹⁸ Singer, “Ethics and Intuitions,” 348; Street, “A Darwinian Dilemma for Realist Theories of Value,” 120; Joyce, *The Evolution of Morality*, 72; Morton, “A New Evolutionary Debunking Argument Against Moral Realism.”

¹⁹ Nisan, “Moral Norms and Social Conventions.”

²⁰ Goldman, “The Right Argument from Moral Disagreement,” 855–64.

²¹ Stratton-Lake, “Intuitionism in Ethics.”

Russ Shafer-Landau proposes that the argument from moral disagreement is self-defeating. He summarizes said argument in terms of moral realism, a foundational commitment of moral intuitionism:

P1: Moral realism is subject to persistent disagreement;

P2: Any theory(s) subject to persistent disagreement is false;

*C: Therefore, moral realism is false.*²²

To this, he claims that the same argument could be applied in reverse. Substituting “moral realism” for “theories against moral realism” results in the conclusion that theories against moral realism are false.

As we will see, though Shafer-Landau’s argument is valid, it is not sound. Concealed within Shafer-Landau’s formulation is what I will term the *agreement premise*: if moral realism is true, then unprejudiced agents reasoning correctly about moral questions would converge on the same moral judgments. The full argument then runs as follows:

P1: The agreement premise is true;

P2: Moral realism is subject to persistent disagreement;

P3: Any theory(s) subject to persistent disagreement is false;

C: Therefore, either (a) moral intuitionism is false, or (b) the agreement premise is false.

The moral realist cannot comfortably accept (b), since the agreement premise follows directly from moral realism itself: if moral facts are objective and self-evident, competent reasoners ought to converge on them. Rejecting (b) would therefore require the moral realist to explain why self-evident facts systematically fail to produce agreement, which is a concession that undermines the intuitionist position. Now apply Shafer-Landau’s reversal: substitute “theories against moral realism” for “moral realism.” The anti-realist faces the same formal structure, but (b) is now acceptable to them. Anti-realists are not committed to any agreement

²² Shafer-Landau, *Whatever Happened to Good and Evil?*, 44–48.

premise about their own view; they can acknowledge that anti-realism attracts only partial agreement without contradiction. The asymmetry shows that the argument from disagreement bears more weight against moral realism than Shafer-Landau's reversal suggests.

IV. Argument from Queerness

Moral intuitionism rests on a foundation of self-evident, non-inferential moral objectivity. However, the very existence of such values can be challenged. In J. L. Mackie's Argument from Queerness, Mackie argues that if objective values exist, then objectively good values would have an inherent "to-be-pursuedness," and objectively bad values would have an inherent "not-to-be-pursuedness."²³ This motivational property is unique to objective moral values and cannot be described in naturalistic terms; in other words, objective values are "queer."²⁴ To claim that such a property is not queer is to invite contradiction with the non-natural property of moral intuitions.²⁵ The argument can be represented in both metaphysical and epistemological versions; however, only the epistemological is necessary here:

P1: If objective moral values exist, they will have to be epistemologically queer, and require bizarre epistemological faculties;

P2: We are unable to utilize such bizarre epistemological faculties;

*C: We should not believe that objective moral values exist.*²⁶

The parity argument, proposed by Terence Cuneo, attempts to prove the existence of objective values. His argument has two main premises: the parity premise (P_P) and the epistemological realism premise (P_E). The parity premise states that moral facts and epistemic facts are analogous to one another since both are normative in that they prescribe behavior or belief independently of subjective desires. The epistemic realism premise holds that belief in the existence of epistemic facts seems natural; otherwise, one could theoretically have misconstrued

²³ Mackie, *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong*, 40; Olson, *Moral Error Theory*, 104.

²⁴ Scholl, *A Defense of Mackie's Moral Error Theory*, 2–3; Mackie, *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong*, 33.

²⁵ Mackie, *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong*, 41.

²⁶ Mackie, *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong*, 38–41; Lillehammer, "The Argument from Queerness," 1–2.

beliefs based only on whims and compulsions.²⁷ His argument is outlined as the following, with an extra “modus tollens” (P_{MT}) premise added for clarity:

P_P : *There can be no epistemic facts if there are no moral facts;*

P_E : *There are epistemic facts;*

P_{MT} : *If there are epistemic facts, then there are moral facts;*

C : *If there are moral facts, then moral realism is true.*²⁸

Believing in moral realism, by definition, entails believing in objective moral values, and in this case, moral intuitionism.

Regardless, though the argument is valid, the parity premise lacks argumentative power. As Richard Joyce notes, moral facts and epistemic facts are disanalogous in several important respects. Examples include how, unlike with moral facts:

1. We acquire epistemic facts involuntarily.
2. Epistemological facts lack the concept of desert, i.e., “deserved reward or punishment.”²⁹
3. We are not reluctant to rely on the judgment of experts when faced with epistemological facts.³⁰

As a result of these discrepancies, we can safely disregard the parity argument and regard the argument as unsound.

Hallvard Lillehammer expresses another objection, claiming that knowledge of objective moral values does not entail the use of epistemologically queer faculties.³¹ He argues that moral facts are analogous to logical facts, since both are causally inert.³² Hence, as Lillehammer points out, if logical facts rely only on an “unproblematic sense ... which we are able to grasp” and not

²⁷ Cuneo, *The Normative Web: An Argument for Moral Realism*, 52–62.

²⁸ On Cuneo’s Defence of The Parity Premise, 1; Cuneo, *The Normative Web: An Argument for Moral Realism*, 6.

²⁹ Merriam-Webster, “Desert.”

³⁰ Joyce, *The Evolution of Morality*, 14–16.

³¹ Lillehammer, “The Argument from Queerness,” 6.

³² Balaguer, “Platonism in Metaphysics.”

some bizarre epistemological faculty, then the same should be the case for moral facts. If one were to deny this argument, the implication would be that we are unable to access logical facts, a highly contentious and counterintuitive claim.³³

While claiming that logical facts are epistemologically inaccessible is certainly absurd, we can nonetheless dispute the notion that logical facts and moral facts are analogous. One key disanalogy is that logical facts lack the “to-be-pursuedness” of moral facts. For example, while the moral fact “giving to charity is good” carries an inherent tendency to act, a tautology such as “all bachelors are unmarried” does not.³⁴

V. Conclusion

I have presented three arguments against moral intuitionism. These arguments suggest that moral intuitionism cannot serve as a credible epistemological foundation for ethics. The unreliability, disagreement, and metaphysical queerness of moral intuitions are not independent problems; they jointly indicate that the foundationalist project is misconceived. This does not entail moral skepticism, but it does demand an alternative account of how moral knowledge is possible.

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³³ Lillehammer, “The Argument from Queerness,” 6.

³⁴ The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica, “Tautology.”

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